'Ascent Series' in red gum and ancient kanooka. Finished with superglue, U-Beaut Shellawax Glow and Traditional Wax, press fit top to bottom. 63 x 55 x 85mm

The development of turning

Australian turner **Vic Wood** reflects on 25 years of woodturning

From the 1950s up to the 90s the attitude of most trade turners was to keep to themselves and not share ideas with one another as it could affect their business. Most 'Trade Turners' were turning between centres making veranda posts, staircase balusters, spindles for staircases, or legs of chairs and tables.

Gradually, automatic turning machines took over therefore there were fewer hands-on turners, but a few were making functional bowls, sugar bowls, platters and candle holders. Some used screws direct into the base of a bowl, others used independent three and four steel chucks and scroll chucks. Now we have four-jaw self-centring chucks with a number of different types of jaws with quick changing systems, helping speed up production.

Prior to the 1990s there was apprentice training in woodturning, there were very few colleges or schools teaching apprentices to turn and a lot of turners worked under a master turner, however, today they are either self-taught or learn from the many structured opportunities provided by organisations such as the American Association of Woodturners, woodturning clubs and chapters and events such as TurnFest in Australia, etc. Here, many skilled professional woodturners share their ideas and skills for artistic woodturning. Because there was less artistic turning and more focus on functional items back in the 1990s compared to today, there appears to be a trend as to who can do the most decorating by using the basic turning as a beginning, and then applying paint, decorative adornments, carving, etc.

Vic Wood

PHOTOGRAPHS BY VIC WOOD

Vic Wood gained his early reputation from his subtle turned and carved wall plaques. He has since developed his woodturning and produces large pieces which are sold mainly through exhibitions, as well as smaller square-edged lidded boxes, which are his signature and are sold by galleries throughout the world. He has travelled throughout Australia and internationally teaching and demonstrating woodturning. He has also been a keynote speaker and demonstrator at national and international symposiums and judges many woodworking shows.
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